

Dhāraṇī Called Mother of the Planetary Spirits

Graha Mātrkā Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 661 · Derge Kangyur

གཟུང་རྒྱས་ཀྱི་ལྷ་ཁོ་བ་བྱུང་གི་ཟུང་།

Toh 661 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Graha Mātṛkā Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Gza' rnam kyī yum zhes bya ba'i gzungs, meaning "The Dhāraṇī Called 'Mother of the Planetary Spirits.'" It belongs to the dhāraṇī and mantra literature of the Kangyur, a broad category of texts preserving sacred formulas and their associated ritual and protective teachings. The text opens with the Blessed One seated upon a vajra throne in a great pastoral city, surrounded by an vast assembly of bodhisattvas, divine beings, planetary spirits, and celestial bodies — including the sun, moon, and the named planets and lunar mansions of Indian cosmology — suggesting that the dhāraṇī it contains is concerned with the pacification or propitiation of planetary and astral forces. As its title implies, this dhāraṇī is presented as a kind of sovereign or "mother" over these planetary spirits, pointing to its likely use in protective or astrological ritual contexts within the broader tradition of Buddhist tantra and dhāraṇī practice.

In the language of India: Graha Mātṛkā Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: the dhāraṇī called "Mother of the Planetary Spirits."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was in the great city of a pastoral dwelling, praised by gods (devas), nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great serpents, māras, the sun, the moon, Mars, Venus, Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn, Rāhu, Ketu, the twenty-eight lunar mansions, and many others — and, consecrated by the sacred pledge of the great vajra, he was seated upon a vajra throne. Together with a great many bodhisattvas — namely the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi, the great bodhisattva Vajra the Fierce, the great bodhisattva Vajra Host, the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi the Bow-Bearer, the great bodhisattva Lord of the Vajra, the great bodhisattva Vajra Ornament, the great bodhisattva Vajra Light, the great bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara the Sovereign, the great bodhisattva All-Seeing, the great bodhisattva Glory of the World, the great bodhisattva Lotus Crest, the great bodhisattva Fully Blooming Face, the great bodhisattva Lotus Essence, the great bodhisattva Lotus Eyes, the great bodhisattva Mañjuśrī the Youthful, the great bodhisattva Maitreya, and others —

surrounded by the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas and facing them, he was teaching the Dharma. He was teaching the Dharma called "The Jewel-Ornament of the Great Array," which is wholesome at the beginning, wholesome in the middle, and wholesome at the end, good in meaning and good in word, unmixed, utterly pure, and completely clarifying.

Then Vajrapāṇi looked upon that assembly, rose, and with the blessing of his own miraculous power circumambulated the Blessed One many hundreds and thousands of times, paid homage, then sat down before him. With pride, he settled himself well in cross-legged posture, gazed at that assembly with a bold and confident air, placed his vajra-joined palms at his own heart, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, the planetary spirits — unbearable, possessed of unbearable forms, violent and endowed with violent minds, wrathful and possessed of wrathful forms — inflict harm upon all sentient beings, they strike them with affliction, they steal away their vitality. Some take away their wealth and food; some take away their very lives; and some who are long-lived sentient beings they cause to be short-lived. In this way, they harm and injure all sentient beings. For the sake of those beings, may the Blessed One please speak — which enumeration of Dharma teachings will serve as a protection for all sentient beings?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Out of compassion, for the benefit of all sentient beings, you ask the Tathāgata for that which is supremely secret, more secret than the most secret. Therefore, listen well and hold it in mind. I shall teach the offerings, oblations, and the excellent recitation — supremely secret, more secret than the most secret — for those planetary spirits of unbearable form, utterly wrathful and utterly terrifying."

"When propitiated with these offerings, one is worshipped; and if harm has been done, the doer of harm, the colors of each of those planetary spirits, how they undergo their changes, the gods and the asuras, the kinnaras and the nāgas, the yakṣas and the rākṣasas, human beings and non-humans, those of fierce and great majesty — the secret mantras and the offerings that pacify their wrath shall be taught in proper order."

Then from the heart of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni himself, a ray of light called "Play of Compassion" radiated forth and entered the crowns of all the planetary spirits. At that very moment, all the planetary spirits, beginning with the Sun, rose up and made divine offerings to the Blessed One,

the Tathāgata Śākyamuni. They prostrated, knelt down, pressed their palms together, and addressed the Blessed One in these words:

"The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, has bestowed upon us the honor of physician. May the Blessed One please teach — through what enumeration of Dharma teachings will we and those who proclaim the Dharma be protected, fully shielded, pacified, and brought to well-being? That which will cause weapons to be abandoned, punishment to be averted, poison to be repelled, poison to be destroyed, boundaries to be sealed, and the earth to be bound — please speak of these."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, declared the offerings to the planetary spirits and their secret mantras:

Om megholkāya svāhā. Om śītāṃśave svāhā. Om raktāṃgakumārāya svāhā. Om budhāya svāhā. Om bṛhaspataye svāhā. Om asurōttamāya svāhā. Om kṛṣṇavarṇāya svāhā. Om amṛtapriyāya svāhā. Om jyotiṣketapai svāhā.

Vajrapāṇi, these are the heart-essences of the secret mantras of the nine planetary spirits; through their recitation all is accomplished. In the center of a maṇḍala of twelve finger-breadths made with incense matching the colors of the respective spirits, offerings are to be made. Offering water is to be presented in vessels of clay, or of copper and similar metals, or of gold and silver, and for each, one hundred and eight recitations are to be performed.

Vajrapāṇi, after that, the words of the dhāraṇī mantra called "Mother of the Planetary Spirits" are to be recited seven times. Then all the planetary spirits will become protectors. One will be freed from the affliction of poverty. Those whose lifespan has been exhausted will be made to have long life.

Vajrapāṇi, for monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen, and whatever other classes of sentient beings there may be — those in whose ear-passages this has resounded — the time of death at an untimely hour will not come to pass.

Vajrapāṇi, in the center of the maṇḍala of the planetary spirits, offerings are to be made, and to any Dharma-proclaimer who recites this each single day, all the planetary spirits will — each with their whole being — bring all their wishes to complete fulfillment. They will also dispel the poverty of those belonging to the same family.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, declared what is called "The Mother of the Planetary Spirits":

Homage to the Buddha.

Homage to Vajradhara.

Homage to Padmadhara.

Homage to the planetary spirits who bring all wishes to complete fulfillment.

Homage to the constellations.

Homage to the twelve houses of the planetary spirits.

Tadyathā: buddhe buddhe, vajre vajre, padme padme, sara sara, prasara prasara, smara smara, krīḍaya krīḍaya, mārāya mārāya, mārḍhaya mārḍhaya, ghātaya ghātaya, sarvatvighnān, kuru kuru, chinda chinda, bhinda bhinda, kṣāpaya kṣāpaya, śānte śānte, dānte dānte, dāmaya dāmaya —

Blessed Lady, quickly reveal yourself to me, together with your retinue, and — protect all sentient beings — protect them, protect them! Turn back the harm of all the planetary spirits and the constellations. Blessed Lady of great miraculous power, dispel the hostile sentient beings. Dry up all my misdeeds.

Caṇḍe caṇḍe, turu turu, caṇḍeni caṇḍeni, muyu muyu, mucu mucu, baha baha, ugre ugrata me, pūraya me, manortham paripūraya, sarva tathāgata adhiṣṭhite samaye svāhā. Oṃ svāhā. Hūṃ svāhā. Hrīḥ svāhā. Dhṛṃ svāhā. Dhṛṃ svāhā. Padmadharā svāhā. Ādityāya svāhā. Saumāya svāhā. Dhāraṇīsutāya svāhā. Buddhāya svāhā. Bṛhaspataye svāhā. Śukrāya svāhā. Kṛṣṇavarṇāya svāhā. Rāhave svāhā. Ketave svāhā. Buddhāya svāhā. Vajradharāya svāhā. Padmadharāya svāhā. Kumārāya svāhā. Sarvaghrebhyaḥ svāhā. Sarvanakṣatrebhyaḥ svāhā. Sarvadvādaśarāśinibhyaḥ svāhā. Sarvopādravebhyaḥ svāhā. Oṃ sarvavidye hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

O Vajrapāṇi, these are the words of the secret mantra of the dhāraṇī called "Mother of the Planetary Spirits," and they are the foundation of all spiritual attainments.

O Vajrapāṇi, these words of the secret mantra of the dhāraṇī of the planetary spirits should be taken up beginning on the seventh day of the waxing fortnight of the last autumn month, keeping the restoration ceremony (poṣadha), and making offerings to the planetary spirits until the fourteenth day, and then maintained from that point on.

Thereafter, whoever reads this aloud continuously through the day and night of the new moon day will not encounter the fear of death for nine years. They will not be threatened by the fear of the planetary spirits, by falling meteors, or by the harm of the constellations. They will recall their past lives. They will

be regarded as having made offerings to all the planetary spirits. And all the planetary spirits will grant them whatever they wish.

Then the planetary spirits paid homage to the Blessed One, said "Excellent! Excellent!" and vanished from sight.

The dhāraṇī called "Mother of the Planetary Spirits" is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The city name rendered "great city of a pastoral dwelling" translates a Tibetan term meaning a large settlement or encampment of nomadic or pastoral character. The exact toponym is unclear; it may be a rendering of a Sanskrit place-name not preserved transparently in this recension.

The planetary spirits listed correspond to the classical Indian nine grahas and related astral beings: Sun, Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, Saturn, Rāhu, and Ketu, with the twenty-eight lunar mansions added. The Tibetan list in the assembly preamble mingles these with divine beings in a way typical of dhāraṇī-sūtra opening assemblies.

"Vajra-joined palms" renders a compound literally meaning "vajra-palms," understood in context as the añjali gesture formed with vajra-interlocked fingers, a tantric mudrā variant of the standard reverential gesture.

- The text ends mid-sentence in the source passage, so the translation breaks off accordingly. The phrase rendered "bestowed upon us the honor of physician" translates བཤམས་པའི་ལཱ་ལྷན་པའི་ལཱ་ལྷན་, literally "appointed a physician's fee" or "assigned a healer's responsibility," indicating the Blessed One has appointed the planetary spirits as healers or protectors; this is a somewhat technical usage and the rendering here favors the sense attested in parallel ritual contexts. The mantra syllables are transliterated as closely as possible from the Tibetan phonetic spelling, which occasionally differs from standard Sanskrit orthography. "Sarvatvighnān" reflects the Tibetan ས་འཁོར་འཁོར་འཁོར་, likely corresponding to Sanskrit sarvavighnān, "all obstacles." The final invocation "Blessed Lady" renders བུ་ཐུ་བུ་ཐུ་བུ་ཐུ་བུ་, the feminine form of Bhagavān, referring to the Mother dhāraṇī personified as a goddess.

- The phrase rendered "last autumn month" translates "ston zla tha chungs," literally "the last of the autumn months." In the Tibetan calendar this refers to the final month of autumn, though the precise correspondence to a fixed calendar month varies by tradition. The instruction to begin on the seventh day of the waxing fortnight and continue through the fourteenth is a standard lunar observance cycle tied to poṣadha practice.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of

spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.